

RETURN TO THE LORD

Lent Prayer and Reflection Guide

Forty Days

Lent is the 40 days (not counting Sundays) leading to Easter, a season the Church has long used for prayer, fasting, repentance, and renewal -- walking with Christ toward the cross so we can walk with Him out of the tomb. This guide gives one theme per week to sit with, rather than a rigid daily checklist. Move at the pace that lets it actually change something in you.

"Return to me with all your heart, with fasting, with weeping, and with mourning." -- Joel 2:12

Week 1: Wilderness

Matthew 4:1-11

Jesus was led into the wilderness before He began His ministry. What wilderness season are you in, and what is God asking you to lean on Him for instead of your own strength?

Reflect

What am I fasting from this Lent, and why -- as a discipline, not just a diet? _____

Prayer

Week 2: Repentance

Psalm 51:10-12

David's prayer after his sin was exposed wasn't shame, it was surrender. Repentance isn't about earning forgiveness -- it's about turning around and walking back toward God.

Reflect

Is there a sin or habit I've been managing instead of actually surrendering to God? _____

Prayer

Week 3: Thirst

John 4:13-14

Jesus told the woman at the well that He offers water that ends thirst for good. What have I been going to instead of Christ to fill a thirst only He can satisfy?

Reflect

What do I turn to first when I'm anxious, lonely, or exhausted -- and is it Him? _____

Prayer

Week 4: Mercy

Luke 15:20-24

The father runs to meet the prodigal son before a word of apology is spoken. Mercy moves first. Who do I need to extend that kind of mercy to, even before they ask?

Reflect

Is there someone I'm withholding forgiveness from while I wait for them to earn it back? _____

Prayer

Week 5: Surrender

Matthew 26:39

"Not as I will, but as you will." Jesus modeled surrender in Gethsemane before He modeled it on the cross.

Reflect

What am I still holding onto with a closed fist instead of an open hand before God? _____

Prayer

Holy Week: The Cross and the Empty Tomb

1 Corinthians 15:3-4

Walk slowly through this week -- Palm Sunday's welcome, Thursday's Last Supper, Friday's cross, and Sunday's empty tomb. Let the whole story land, not just the ending.

Reflect

As this Lent ends, what is one way I want Easter to actually change how I live? _____

Prayer
